

## Field Overview: Disciplinary Structure and Growth Dynamics

Annual output in the Active Inference literature rose from  $\{\{\text{YEAR\_START\_PUBS}\}\}$  papers in 2005 to  $\{\{\text{PEAK\_YEAR\_PUBS}\}\}$  papers in 2025—a transition from a niche within theoretical neuroscience to a multi-disciplinary research program spanning three primary domains and eight tracked categories. The corpus start of 2005 was chosen to capture Energy-Based Model and variational Bayesian antecedents [dayan1995helmholtz](#), [lecun2006tutorial](#) that preceded the formal introduction of the Free Energy Principle in 2006 [friston2006free](#) and its subsequent full elaboration [friston2010free](#). Our corpus, extracted from arXiv, Semantic Scholar, and OpenAlex and deduplicated to  $N = 849$  papers (2005–2026), captures the breadth, tempo, and internal architecture of this expansion (Figure 1).

### Active Inference Literature by Subfield (N=847)

